

Jasminum grandiflorum (Oleaceae)

Jasmine

Description Slender evergreen rambler growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has dark green compound leaves and large, sweetly scented tubular white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northern India, Pakistan, and the northwestern Himalayas, jasmine is now cultivated as a garden plant and for its essential oil.

Parts Used Flowers, essential oil.



Jasmine flowers are the source of an essential oil that is used to treat stress and depression.

Constituents Jasmine's volatile oil contains benzyl alcohol, benzyl acetate, linalool, and linalyl acetate.

History & Folklore Jasmine was introduced to Europe in the 16th century, and is mainly used as a source of perfume.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Jasmine flowers make a calming and sedative infusion, taken to relieve tension. The oil is considered antidepressant and relaxing. It is used externally to soothe dry or sensitive skin. Due to frequent adulteration, the oil is rarely used in aromatherapy.

Related Species Actually native to Southeast Asia, Arabian jasmine (*J. sambac*) is used as an eyewash, is added to tea (*Camellia sinensis*, p. 181) to produce jasmine tea, and is used in Buddhist ceremonies.

Caution Jasmine essential oil should not be taken internally.

Jateorhiza palmata
(Menispermaceae)

Calumba

Description Creeping vine with a perennial rootstock, growing to a great height and often reaching the tops of trees. Has large palm-shaped

leaves, small greenish-white flowers, with male and female flowers on separate plants, and round, fleshy fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the rainforests of eastern Africa, especially Mozambique and Madagascar, calumba is also grown in other tropical regions. The roots are dug up in dry weather in March and dried.

Parts Used Bark.

Constituents Calumba contains isoquinoline alkaloids (notably palmatine, columbamine, and jatrorrhizine), diterpene bitter principles, mucilage, and volatile oil (about 1%).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Profoundly bitter, calumba is an extremely good remedy for underactive or weakened digestion, stimulating stomach acid production and increasing appetite. It is a specific for loss of appetite and anorexia, and by making the stomach more acidic (and therefore hostile to pathogens) helps to prevent digestive infections and improve the breakdown and absorption of foods. It is a useful treatment for chronic intestinal infection such as dysentery.

Research Calumba's bitterness is due both to the bitter principles and the alkaloids. Palmatine and jatrorrhizine reduce blood pressure, palmatine is a uterine stimulant, and jatrorrhizine is sedative and antifungal.

Other Species Calumba has much in common with gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99), although it owes its bitterness to a different range of constituents.

Caution Avoid during pregnancy.

Juglans cinerea (Juglandaceae)

Butternut

Description Deciduous tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has gray bark, long leaves with many leaflets, male catkins and female flowers, and an oval-shaped fruit containing a hard dark-colored nut.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North American forests, butternut is cultivated for its timber in other temperate regions. The bark is collected in autumn.

Part Used Inner bark.

Constituents Contains naphthaquinones (including juglone, juglandin, and juglandic acid), a fixed and a volatile oil, and tannins. The naphthaquinones have an approximately similar laxative effect to the anthraquinones found in plants such as senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75) and Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126). Juglone is purgative, antimicrobial, antiparasitic, and cancer-inhibiting.

History & Folklore Butternut bark was employed by Native Americans and New World settlers as a laxative and tonic remedy. Butternut

was used to treat a variety of conditions, including rheumatic and arthritic joints, headaches, dysentery, constipation, and wounds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used to this day as a laxative and tonic, butternut is a valuable remedy for chronic constipation, gently encouraging regular bowel movements. It is especially beneficial if combined with a carminative herb, such as ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155) or angelica (*Angelica archangelica*, p. 168). Butternut also lowers cholesterol levels, and promotes the clearance of waste products by the liver. It has a positive reputation in treating intestinal worms, and, being antimicrobial and astringent, it has been prescribed as a treatment for dysentery.

Related Species Black walnut (*J. nigra*) is used in the same way as butternut. The bark of the walnut tree (*J. regia*) is used as a gentle purgative, and is also applied to skin afflictions. The nut is used in Chinese herbal medicine as a kidney tonic. The nuts of both varieties are highly nutritious, lower cholesterol levels, and contain significant quantities of alpha-linolenic acid.

Juniperus communis

(Cupressaceae)

Juniper

Description Coniferous shrub sometimes growing to 49 ft (15 m). Has slender twigs with whorls of needle-like leaves, yellow male and blue female flowers on separate plants, and spherical blue-black fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Juniper is found in Europe, southwestern Asia up to the Himalayas, and North America, where it grows from southern coastal sites to more northerly moorland and mountainous regions. The ripe fruit (berries) is gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Fruit, essential oil.

Constituents Juniper contains 1–2% volatile oil, consisting of over 60 compounds, which include myrcene, sabinene, alpha- and beta-pinene, and cineole. Juniper also contains tannins, diterpenes, sugars, resin, and vitamin C.

History & Folklore Juniper is the main flavoring used in gin. Juniper berries are still mostly gathered from the wild. In former times, sprigs of juniper flung into the fire were thought to protect against evil spirits.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Juniper is tonic, diuretic, and strongly antiseptic within the urinary tract. It is a valuable remedy for cystitis, and helps relieve fluid retention, but should be avoided in cases of kidney disease. In the digestive system, juniper is warming and settling, easing colic and supporting the function of the stomach. Taken internally or applied externally, juniper is helpful